

Health Insurance in Tennessee

What nobody tells you

A plain-English walkthrough of your real coverage options, the numbers that actually matter, when you can enroll, and how to choose a plan that protects you when it counts.

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WHAT'S INSIDE

01 A Note From Denton

02 Who We Help Most

03 Your Three Real Options

04 The 4 Numbers That Matter

05 Mistakes to Avoid

06 Is a Private PPO Right for You?

07 When You Can Enroll

08 What a Free Review Looks Like

INTRODUCTION

A Note From Denton

If you work for yourself, finding health insurance can feel like navigating a system that was not built for you. That is because it was not. The market was designed around employer coverage, so if you are self-employed, a 1099 contractor, a freelancer, or a small business owner, your options look very different from what your employed friends have.

A quick word on me. I was born and raised in Nolensville, studied at the University of Tennessee and MTSU, and today I live in Smyrna and run DC Insurance from here. I am an independent broker, not a captive agent or a call center. I shop the whole market and tell you what I would do if I were in your seat.

This guide covers your real options, how to compare them, what to watch out for, and when you can actually enroll. No jargon. No sales pitch. If you want the longer version, the [complete guide for self-employed Tennesseans](#) is on the website.

Denton Casey

Independent health insurance broker, DC Insurance, Smyrna, TN



Denton Casey

Founder, DC Insurance
Born & raised in Nolensville
Univ. of Tennessee & MTSU
Licensed in 15 states
[More about Denton](#)

OUR CLIENTS

Who We Help Most

1099 Contractors ›

Independent contractors with 1099 income and no employer plan.

Owner-Operators & Truckers ›

You own the rig and the business, so nationwide networks matter.

Musicians & Touring Artists ›

Session players, songwriters, and artists, most of them 1099.

Consultants & Freelancers ›

Designers, marketers, IT pros, and coaches running their own business.

Retiring Before 65 ›

Bridging the years between employer coverage and Medicare.

Travel Nurses & Healthcare Contractors

Per diem and travel workers who need coverage across state lines.

Realtors & Real Estate Agents ›

Commission income and no benefits, so coverage has to work around a variable paycheck.

Small Business Owners ›

Coverage for you, with options for employees that skip group complexity.

Contractors & Skilled Trades ›

Electricians, plumbers, HVAC techs, and roofers running their own crews.

Gig Economy Workers ›

Platform workers classified as contractors with no employer benefits.

Salon Owners & Beauty Pros

Booth renters, stylists, and nail techs handling their own benefits.

Therapists & Private Practice

Counselors, chiropractors, and practitioners managing their own benefits.

Your Three Real Options

Most self-employed Tennesseans do not realize they have three distinct lanes. Every review I do puts all three side by side.

LANE 1

ACA Marketplace Plans

Plans on healthcare.gov are open to any Tennessee resident who meets basic eligibility. They are guaranteed issue, so you cannot be turned down for your health history.

Best for: households whose income qualifies them for a meaningful premium tax credit, and anyone with health history that rules out underwriting.

Watch out for: regional networks, high deductibles on lower tiers, and the fact that above the subsidy line you pay the full price.

[ACA vs. private health insurance in Tennessee](#) > [Earn too much for subsidies?](#) >

LANE 2

Medically Underwritten Private PPO Plans

Bought outside the marketplace. These go through medical underwriting, so your health history shapes eligibility and price. In exchange you typically get nationwide networks, no referrals, and year-round enrollment.

Best for: people in good health who earn above the subsidy line or need a network that follows them across state lines.

Watch out for: underwriting is more involved than most people expect, and not everyone qualifies. If you do not, the marketplace is still open to you.

[Private PPO health insurance in Tennessee](#) > [What medical underwriting means](#) >

LANE 3

Employer Coverage, Yours or a Spouse's

If you or your spouse has access to an employer plan, it belongs in the comparison. Sometimes it wins. Sometimes a private plan for part of the household costs less in total than the family tier.

Best for: households where the employer pays a large share of the premium, or someone has ongoing care needs.

Watch out for: adding a spouse or kids can change the math sharply. Price each piece separately before defaulting to the family tier.

[When a spouse's employer plan is on the table](#) >

On top of any lane: supplemental coverage. Accident, critical illness, and hospital indemnity plans pay cash benefits directly to you and can soften a high deductible. They work alongside a primary plan, never instead of one. [How supplemental coverage works](#) >

The 4 Numbers That Actually Matter

Most people shop on one number, the monthly premium. These four decide how a plan performs when you actually use it.

1 Monthly Premium

What you pay every month whether or not you use the plan. A lower premium usually means you pay more when you need care.

2 Deductible

What you pay out of pocket before the plan starts sharing costs. A \$6,000 deductible means you cover the first \$6,000 of covered expenses yourself each year.

3 Coinsurance

After the deductible, you and the plan split costs. At 80/20 the plan pays 80% and you pay 20%, until you reach your out-of-pocket maximum.

4 Out-of-Pocket Maximum

The ceiling on what you pay for covered care in a year. This is the most important number for protecting against a serious health event.

Run the bad year, not just the good one. Twelve months of a \$300 premium plus an \$8,700 out-of-pocket maximum is \$12,300 in a bad year. Twelve months of a \$500 premium plus a \$3,000 maximum is \$9,000. The cheaper premium is not always the cheaper plan. [How to compare plans >](#)

WHAT TO AVOID

Common Mistakes to Avoid

1 Choosing a plan on premium alone

The lowest premium often carries the highest deductible and out-of-pocket costs. Model a normal year and a bad year before you decide. [The real cost of cheap coverage >](#)

2 Assuming the marketplace is your only option

If you are in good health, a private PPO may give you a broader network and a lower deductible. For some households the total cost comes in lower too. It is worth pricing.

3 Defaulting to COBRA after a job ends

COBRA keeps your old plan, but you pay the full premium. Losing job coverage usually opens a 60-day window to compare other options first. [Options beyond COBRA >](#)

4 Not reviewing coverage every year

Income, health, networks, and plans all change. A plan that fit two years ago may not fit today, and a review costs nothing.

5 Going it alone

An independent broker who shops the whole market explains what you are actually buying. You pay nothing for the help, because the carrier pays the broker.

Is a Private PPO Right for You?

Not right for everyone, but for many self-employed Tennesseans it is the strongest option on the table. Here is how to tell.

You may be a good candidate if you:

- ✓ Are in generally good health
- ✓ Earn too much for a meaningful ACA subsidy
- ✓ Want a nationwide network of doctors and specialists
- ✓ Prefer a lower deductible and more predictable costs
- ✓ Want to see a specialist without a referral
- ✓ Travel for work and need coverage that follows you

A marketplace plan may serve you better if you:

- × Have health history that affects underwriting
- × Qualify for a substantial premium tax credit
- × Are expecting a baby or in the middle of ongoing treatment

Bottom line: the only way to know which lane wins for you is to compare them side by side with real numbers. That is exactly what a free review does. [Book one here >](#)

TIMING

When You Can Enroll

ACA marketplace

Open enrollment begins November 1. Outside that window you need a qualifying life event. [Open enrollment in Tennessee >](#)

Private PPO

Year-round. You can apply any month, though underwriting takes time, so start before you need the coverage. [How private plans work >](#)

Life events

Losing job coverage, moving, marriage, or a new baby can open a Special Enrollment Period, typically 60 days. [Special enrollment explained >](#)

NEXT STEPS

What a Free Review Looks Like

1 We start with your situation

Your income, your health, your current coverage if any, and the doctors you want to keep.

2 I price every lane

ACA marketplace, private PPO, and any employer plan in the household, with real numbers for your situation.

3 We walk through the comparison

Deductibles, networks, and out-of-pocket maximums, and what each plan costs in a normal year versus a bad one.

4 You decide

No pressure and no timeline. If what you already have is your best option, I will tell you.

BOOK YOUR FREE REVIEW

Ready to see your real options?

Book a free 15-minute call. No sales pitch. No pressure. Just a straight look at your options, with real numbers for your situation.

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BOOK ONLINE

tidycal.com/denton/intro-call

Book your free review >

KEEP READING ON THE WEBSITE

Self-employed health insurance in Tennessee >

Open enrollment in Tennessee: what to sort out first >

ACA vs. private health insurance in Tennessee >

What an independent broker actually does >